

Bangladesh Traffic Laws & Rules

Complete Reference Guide — Road Transport Act 2018 + 2024 Amendments

Overview and Legal Framework

Bangladesh's traffic is governed by the Road Transport Act 2018, which came into force on November 1, 2019, replacing the old Motor Vehicle Ordinance of 1983. The act was further amended in 2024 to revise certain fines, penalties, and bail conditions. The Bangladesh Road Transport Authority (BRTA) is the main regulatory body overseeing all transport-related matters, while the Dhaka Metropolitan Police (DMP) and Bangladesh Metropolitan Police enforce fines and rules on the ground. Under the old Motor Vehicle Ordinance 1983, the maximum fine for any traffic violation was only Tk 5,000 and the minimum was Tk 100. Under the new Road Transport Act 2018, the maximum fine can go up to Tk 5,00,000 (five lakh taka) and the minimum fine is Tk 5,000. If a driver is caught by a special traffic police checkpost or a police patrol car, the fine amount is doubled automatically.

Driving Licence Rules and Penalties

No person is allowed to drive any motor vehicle on a public road without a valid driving licence. This is governed under Section 4 of the Road Transport Act 2018. Driving with an expired licence is treated the same as driving without a licence. The penalty for driving without a licence or with an expired licence is a fine of Tk 25,000 or up to six months of imprisonment, or both. Under the 2024 amendment, a lighter clause was also introduced where a one-month jail term and a Tk 5,000 fine may be applied in certain specific cases at the discretion of the authority.

To be eligible to apply for a driving licence, an applicant must have passed at least the 8th grade. Previously, no academic qualification was required to obtain a licence. The BRTA is responsible for issuing all categories of driving licences. Providing false information while applying for or in relation to a driving licence is a serious offence, punishable by two years of imprisonment and a fine of Tk 3,00,000 (three lakh taka). Before the 2024 amendment, this fine was Tk 5,00,000 (five lakh taka). All driving licences must be kept valid and renewed before expiry. A driver must always carry the original driving licence while operating any motor vehicle on a public road.

Vehicle Registration Rules and Penalties

Every motor vehicle operating on a public road must have a valid registration certificate issued by the BRTA. Driving a vehicle without registration is punishable by a fine of Tk 50,000 or up to six months of imprisonment, or both. Driving without a route permit is fined at Tk 1,500 for the first offence and Tk 2,500 for the second offence. Driving without a fitness certificate is punishable by a fine of Tk 25,000 or up to six months of imprisonment, or both. All vehicle registration certificates must be renewed periodically as required by BRTA regulations. The registration certificate must be carried inside the vehicle at all times.

Vehicle Fitness Certificate Rules

Every motor vehicle must obtain a valid fitness certificate from the BRTA before operating on public roads. The fitness certificate confirms that the vehicle meets all mechanical and safety standards required by law, including the condition of brakes, lights, tyres, steering, and other essential components. A vehicle without a valid fitness certificate is considered unfit for road use. Operating an unfit vehicle is punishable by a fine of Tk 25,000 or up to six months of imprisonment, or both. Vehicle owners must renew their fitness certificate periodically as required by the BRTA and must not allow an unfit vehicle to be operated on any public road.

Vehicle Insurance Rules

Every motor vehicle must be insured before it is allowed on public roads in Bangladesh. Valid insurance is a mandatory document that must be carried inside the vehicle at all times. If a motor vehicle is found operating without valid insurance, the owner or driver will be fined Tk 3,000. This rule was formally reinforced and made strictly enforceable under the 2024 amendment to the Road Transport Act. Insurance must be renewed before it expires and the original certificate must be produced during traffic checks.

Tax Token Rules

Every motor vehicle must have a valid tax token, which serves as proof that the required road tax has been paid to the government. Driving without a valid tax token is an offence and can result in fines during routine traffic checks. The tax token must be renewed annually and must be kept inside the vehicle at all times along with the registration certificate, fitness certificate, insurance, and route permit. Failure to produce a valid tax token during a traffic inspection is treated as a document violation.

Document Carrying Rules

All drivers are legally required to carry their driving licence, vehicle registration certificate, fitness certificate, tax token, route permit, and insurance certificate at all times while driving. Traffic police require original documents during inspections and not photocopies. Failure to carry any of these documents is an offence under the Road Transport Act. Drivers must ensure all documents are current, valid, and not expired before operating any motor vehicle on a public road.

Traffic Signal and Road Discipline Rules

Running a red light is a punishable offence under the Road Transport Act. The fine for disobeying a traffic signal is Tk 500. Driving on the wrong side of a one-way road is fined at Tk 200. Disobeying a police officer's orders or failing to cooperate with traffic police is fined at Tk 500. General traffic violations that do not fall under a specific section are fined at Tk 200 for the first offence and Tk 400 for the second offence. Reckless driving is fined at Tk 300 for the first offence and Tk 500 for the second offence. A higher penalty of Tk 10,000 or up to three months of imprisonment, or both, applies for reckless driving and risky

overtaking under the stricter provisions of the act. Traffic intersections in many areas are now monitored by cameras that record violations.

Speed Limit Rules

Speed limits in Bangladesh vary depending on the type of road and the area. In urban and residential areas, the general speed limit for private vehicles is 30 to 50 kilometers per hour. On national highways, the speed limit for private cars is typically up to 80 kilometers per hour. Heavy vehicles such as buses and trucks are subject to lower speed limits than private cars on the same roads. Drivers must always follow the posted speed limit signs and reduce speed in school zones, hospital zones, and pedestrian-heavy areas. Violating speed limits can result in fines or licence suspension depending on the severity and frequency of the offence.

Overtaking Rules

Overtaking must be done safely and only from the right side of the vehicle being overtaken unless road markings specifically permit otherwise. Overtaking is prohibited on curves, at intersections, near pedestrian crossings, on bridges, and in areas with poor visibility. Risky overtaking that endangers other road users is treated as reckless driving and is punishable by a fine of Tk 10,000 or up to three months of imprisonment, or both. Racing between public transport vehicles on public roads is strictly prohibited and is also treated as reckless driving under the act.

Horn and Noise Rules

Using a hydraulic horn or any banned pressure horn is a serious offence under the Road Transport Act. The maximum penalty for using a banned horn is a fine of Tk 10,000 or up to three months of imprisonment, or both. Under the DMP fine chart, using a hydraulic horn carries a fine of Tk 100 as a base penalty. All vehicles must use only approved horns that meet the noise regulations set by the BRTA. Unnecessary and excessive use of horns in hospital zones, residential areas, and school zones is also considered a violation.

Vehicle Modification Rules

No person is allowed to modify a motor vehicle without proper approval from the BRTA or relevant authorities. Illegal modifications include changing the length or width of the vehicle, altering seat arrangements, modifying wheel size, changing brakes, gears, horn, indicators, exhaust system, or the colour of the vehicle. Using a left-hand drive vehicle without proper permission also falls under the illegal modification category. The penalty for illegal vehicle modification is a fine of up to Tk 3,00,000 (three lakh taka) or up to three years of imprisonment, or both. This is governed under Section 40 of the Road Transport Act 2018, which lists 18 different classifications of illegal modifications.

Common modifications that many people assume are acceptable but are actually illegal include steel bumper additions, aftermarket exhaust systems, bigger or wider wheels, modified lighting, and changed indicators. Selling a vehicle with external modifications done without approval is fined at Tk 2,000 under the DMP fine chart. All modifications, even minor ones, require prior approval from the BRTA before being installed on a vehicle.

Vehicle Overloading Rules

No motor vehicle should carry passengers or goods beyond its approved laden weight. The laden weight refers to the combined weight of the vehicle, passengers, goods, and fuel together. Violating the overloading rule is punishable by a fine of Tk 1,00,000 (one lakh taka) or up to one year of imprisonment, or both. Under the DMP fine chart, overloading is fined at Tk 1,000 for the first offence and Tk 2,000 for the second offence. Vehicle owners and operators are equally responsible for ensuring that their vehicles are not overloaded before being operated on any road.

Seatbelt Rules

Wearing a seatbelt is mandatory for the driver and all front-seat passengers in any motor vehicle. Failure to wear a seatbelt is a punishable offence under the Road Transport Act. All vehicle passengers are expected to wear seatbelts wherever seatbelts are installed. Seatbelt laws are strictly enforced, especially in Dhaka and other major cities. Drivers are responsible for ensuring that all passengers in the front seat are buckled up before the vehicle is operated.

Helmet and Motorcycle Safety Rules

Motorcycle riders and pillion passengers must wear proper safety helmets at all times while riding. Riding a motorcycle without proper safety gear including a helmet is fined at Tk 300. If the absence of safety gear results in bodily injury or property damage in an accident, the fine increases to Tk 1,000. Helmets must be of approved quality and must be properly fastened while riding. Two-wheelers must follow all traffic rules including signal compliance, lane discipline, and speed limits just like any other motor vehicle.

Mobile Phone and Distracted Driving Rules

Using a mobile phone while driving is a punishable offence in Bangladesh. It is considered one of the leading causes of road accidents. Drivers who need to make or receive calls must use a hands-free device or safely pull over to the side of the road before using their phone. Any activity that distracts the driver from operating the vehicle safely, including texting, using apps, or watching videos while driving, is treated as a violation under the Road Transport Act. Violations are subject to fines at the discretion of the traffic authority.

Vehicle Emission Rules

Vehicles emitting excessive black smoke from their exhaust are in violation of both environmental regulations and traffic rules. The fine for a vehicle found emitting black smoke is Tk 200 under the DMP fine chart. Vehicle owners are responsible for ensuring their vehicles are properly maintained and serviced regularly so that they do not violate emission standards. Vehicles that consistently fail emission standards may be considered unfit and can be taken off the road by authorities.

Public Transport Conduct Rules

Drivers and conductors of public transport vehicles such as buses, minibuses, and auto-rickshaws must behave responsibly and follow all traffic rules at all times. Conductors are not allowed to hang outside moving vehicles or solicit passengers in a way that disrupts traffic flow. Overcharging passengers beyond the officially set government fare is an offence. Racing between public transport vehicles on public roads is strictly prohibited. Stopping public transport vehicles at unauthorized locations to pick up or drop off passengers is also a punishable offence. Public transport vehicles must stop only at designated bus stops and halts.

Highway and Inter-District Travel Rules

All vehicles operating on national highways must carry a valid route permit issued by the BRTA. Public transport vehicles such as buses and minibuses must follow their designated routes and are not allowed to deviate without permission. Stopping vehicles at unauthorized locations on highways to pick up or drop off passengers is a punishable offence. Vehicles must maintain proper lane discipline on highways and must not use emergency lanes for regular travel. Emergency lanes must be kept clear at all times for use by emergency vehicles such as ambulances, fire trucks, and police vehicles.

CNG and Three-Wheeler Rules

CNG-powered auto-rickshaws and other three-wheelers must operate strictly within their approved zones as designated by the BRTA. CNG autos are not permitted to operate outside city limits or on national highways unless specifically authorized by a valid route permit. Route violations by CNG autos are subject to fines. These vehicles must also carry all required documents including registration certificate, fitness certificate, route permit, insurance, and tax token. Overloading of passengers in CNG autos beyond the approved capacity is also an offence.

Rickshaw and Non-Motorized Vehicle Rules

Rickshaws and other non-motorized vehicles are prohibited on many major roads and highways in Dhaka and other major cities. Operating a rickshaw on a restricted road is an offence. Non-motorized vehicles must stay in their designated lanes where available and must not obstruct the flow of motorized traffic. In areas where dedicated rickshaw lanes exist, non-motorized vehicles must use those lanes only and must

not encroach into motorized traffic lanes.

Parking Rules

Vehicles must not be parked in restricted zones, on footpaths, in front of fire hydrants, at bus stops, near school entrances, in front of hospital gates, or in any area where no-parking signs are displayed. Illegally parked vehicles can be towed away by traffic authorities, and the owner is required to pay a fine along with towing charges to recover the vehicle. Double parking, which blocks other vehicles from moving, is also a punishable offence. Parking on the main carriageway of a road without hazard lights on is also considered a violation.

Night Driving Rules

Vehicles must use proper headlights during night driving. High-beam headlights must be switched to low-beam when approaching oncoming vehicles to avoid blinding other drivers. Vehicles parked on the road at night must use hazard lights or parking lights to warn other road users. Driving without functioning headlights at night is treated as a vehicle fitness violation and can result in fines. All vehicles must ensure that their tail lights, brake lights, and indicator lights are functional before operating on public roads.

Pedestrian and Road User Rules

Pedestrians must use designated crossings, footpaths, and zebra crossings wherever available. Jaywalking across busy roads and highways is dangerous and discouraged. Vehicle drivers are legally required to give way to pedestrians at marked zebra crossings. Ignoring pedestrian crossings or endangering pedestrians is a punishable offence under the act. Almost 80 percent of traffic accident victims in Dhaka are pedestrians struck by motor vehicles, making pedestrian safety a critical concern under Bangladesh's traffic laws.

Accident Reporting Rules

If a road accident occurs, the driver, conductor, or any representative of the vehicle is legally required to immediately inform the nearest police station and the Fire Service. Failure to report an accident to the authorities is punishable by a fine of Tk 20,000 or one month of imprisonment, or both. The same penalty applies if the driver or vehicle representative fails to ensure that injured persons are transported to a hospital immediately after an accident. Leaving the scene of an accident without reporting it or assisting injured persons is treated as a serious offence.

Accident Causing Serious Injury or Death — Section 105

Under Section 105 of the Road Transport Act 2018, if any person is seriously injured or killed as a result of a motor vehicle accident, the driver is liable under the relevant sections of the Penal Code 1860. This

includes sections ranging from Section 302 to Section 304B of the Penal Code. The maximum punishment under these sections can go up to the death sentence in the most severe cases. Causing death by rash or negligent driving on a public road is punishable under Section 304B of the Penal Code with imprisonment of up to three years, or a fine, or both.

Under the 2024 amendment to the Road Transport Act, most traffic offences that were previously non-bailable have been made bailable. However, Section 105, which covers accidents resulting in death or serious injury to any person, remains strictly a non-bailable offence. This means a person accused under Section 105 cannot be released on bail as a matter of right and must go through the judicial process for any possible relief.

Drug and Alcohol Rules

Driving under the influence of alcohol or any narcotic substance is strictly prohibited under Bangladesh law. A driver found to be intoxicated or under the influence of drugs while operating a vehicle can be charged under both the Road Transport Act 2018 and the relevant sections of the Narcotics Control Act of Bangladesh. The BRTA has acknowledged that random dope testing of drivers on the road is a key requirement under the law. Authorities are currently working on building the infrastructure needed to conduct widespread and consistent random dope tests on drivers across the country.

Bail Conditions Under the 2024 Amendment

Under the original Road Transport Act 2018, three specific offences were classified as non-bailable. Following the Road Transport Amendment Act 2024, all but one of these offences have been made bailable. The only offence that remains non-bailable is Section 105, which deals with accidents where a person is killed or seriously injured. Violation of technical instructions of a motor vehicle, which was previously non-bailable, has now been made bailable under the 2024 amendment. This change was made to reduce the burden on the courts and to bring the law in line with the principle of proportionality.

Enforcement Authorities and BRTA

The Bangladesh Road Transport Authority (BRTA) is the apex body responsible for implementing all traffic laws, issuing driving licences, vehicle registration certificates, route permits, and fitness certificates. The BRTA head office is located at BRTA Bhaban, Chairmanbari, New Airport Road, Banani, Dhaka-1212. The Dhaka Metropolitan Police (DMP) Traffic Division and Bangladesh Metropolitan Police actively enforce traffic rules and collect fines on the ground. Traffic cameras have been installed at many major intersections in Dhaka to monitor and record traffic violations automatically. Traffic laws in Bangladesh are frequently updated and all drivers, vehicle owners, and road users are expected to stay informed about any changes through BRTA official channels or reliable sources.

Summary of Key Fines and Penalties

Driving without a licence: Tk 25,000 fine or up to 6 months jail or both. Driving with expired licence: Tk 25,000 fine or up to 6 months jail or both. No vehicle registration: Tk 50,000 fine or up to 6 months jail or both. No fitness certificate: Tk 25,000 fine or up to 6 months jail or both. No route permit: Tk 1,500 (first offence), Tk 2,500 (second offence). No insurance: Tk 3,000 fine. False information on licence: Tk 3,00,000 fine and 2 years jail. Running a red light: Tk 500 fine. Wrong way on one-way road: Tk 200 fine. Disobeying police orders: Tk 500 fine. General traffic violation: Tk 200 (first), Tk 400 (second). Reckless driving (base): Tk 300 (first), Tk 500 (second). Reckless driving (severe/risky overtaking): Tk 10,000 or 3 months jail or both. Using hydraulic horn: Tk 100 to Tk 10,000 or 3 months jail or both. Riding without helmet: Tk 300, or Tk 1,000 if injury results. Black smoke emission: Tk 200. Illegal vehicle modification: Up to Tk 3,00,000 or 3 years jail or both. Overloading (DMP chart): Tk 1,000 (first), Tk 2,000 (second). Overloading (severe): Tk 1,00,000 or 1 year jail or both. Not reporting accident: Tk 20,000 or 1 month jail or both. Accident causing death or serious injury (Section 105): Non-bailable, punishable under Penal Code up to death sentence. All fines are doubled if caught by special checkpoint or patrol car.